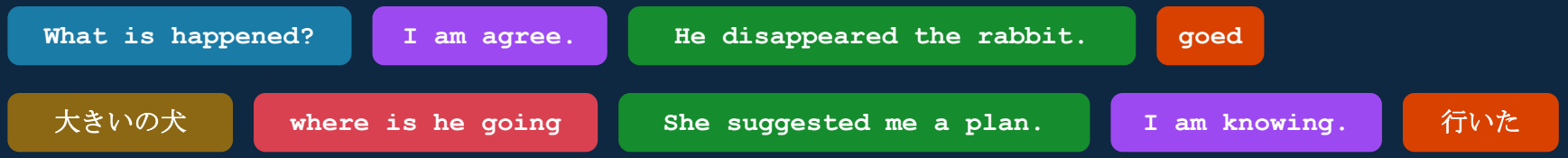
Class 6

Academic reading 4: Discussion

Corpus research 5: Examples of interlanguage errors

Interlanguage

What learners' "errors" reveal about grammar — and how to find them yourself in a corpus



What Is Interlanguage?

A learner's own, rule-governed grammar between the L1 and the target (Selinker 1972)

L1

日本語

賛成です。

INTERLANGUAGE

Learner grammar

`I am agree.`

TARGET

English

`I agree.`

1 Systematic

Learners follow rules — just not always the target's rules. "goed" shows the -ed rule has been learned.

2 Dynamic

It changes over time, often through predictable stages shared by learners with different L1s.

3 Can fossilize

Some features stop developing and persist even in very advanced learners.

Key idea An error is evidence. Each one points to a hypothesis in the learner's head: transfer from the L1, a rule stretched too far, or a developmental stage. A learner corpus lets us see which errors are common, who makes them, and when.

Where Interlanguage Shows Up

19 phenomena, grouped by the layer of the clause they involve

VP (verb phrase)

3 phenomena

Verbs and their arguments

- motion
- overtransitive
- dative

VoiceP (voice phrase)

3 phenomena

Active, passive, middle

- overpassive
- middle
- pseudo-passive

AspP (aspect phrase)

2 phenomena

Tense and aspect marking

- be-insertion
- stative -ing

CP (sentence level phenomena)

4 phenomena

Topics, relatives, questions

- topic-comment
- resumptive
- inversion
- islands

DP (determiner phrase)

3 phenomena

Articles and pronouns

- articles
- null subject
- overt pronoun

Head

5 phenomena

Heads displaced or doubled

- double marking
- goed
- MSIH
- neg
- V2

Penn Treebank POS Tags

VP: Verbs and Their Arguments

Which arguments a verb takes — and how the L1 packages events

2.1.1 Motion Event Typology Transfer

L1 Path/Manner patterns carry over: verb-framed Spanish and Japanese (泳いで渡った) put Path in the verb.

Key lit. Slobin (1996) · Cadierno (2004)

LEARNER vs TARGET

△ He crossed the river swimming.

✓ He swam across the river.

TRY IN A CORPUS `crossed * swimming`

L2 日本語 →

2.1.2 Overtransitivization

Intransitive verbs are pushed into transitive or causative frames, as if the subject caused the event.

Key lit. Bowerman (1974) · Ambridge et al. (2008)

LEARNER vs TARGET

✗ He disappeared the rabbit.

✓ He made the rabbit disappear.

TRY IN A CORPUS `disappeared (the|him|her)`

2.1.3 Overgeneralized Dative Alternation

The double-object frame (V NP NP) spreads to Latinate verbs that only allow “to”.

Key lit. Mazurkewich (1984) · Inagaki (2001)

LEARNER vs TARGET

✗ He explained me the question.

✓ He explained the question to me.

TRY IN A CORPUS `(explained|suggested) (me|him|her)`

VoiceP: Active, Passive, Middle

When learners add — or leave out — passive morphology

2.2.1 Overpassivization

Passive be + V-en is added to unaccusative verbs such as happen, appear and die.

Key lit. Ju 2000 · Oshita 2000 · Ortega et al. in press

LEARNER vs TARGET

✗ What is happened?
✓ What happened?

TRY IN A CORPUS `(is|was) (happened|died)`

2.2.2 Underpassivization & Avoiding the Middle

Middles (active form, passive meaning) are rejected, or passives are avoided where English expects them.

Key lit. Balcom (1997) · Gao (2016)

LEARNER vs TARGET

△ This book is sold well.
✓ This book sells well.

TRY IN A CORPUS `(sells|sold) well`

2.2.3 Pseudo-Passives

The patient is placed in subject position without any passive morphology.

Key lit. Yip (1995) · Han (2000, 2006)

LEARNER vs TARGET

✗ These sentences can analyze many ways.
✓ These sentences can be analyzed in many ways.

TRY IN A CORPUS `can (analyze|solve) [.,]`

AspP: Tense and Aspect Marking

Extra be and extra -ing: marking time where English does not

2.3.1 Copula Be-Insertion

A redundant be appears before lexical or stative verbs, working as a default marker of tense or aspect. Japanese 賛成です may make “am agree” feel natural.

Key lit. Zobl (1982) · Ionin & Wexler (2002)

LEARNER vs TARGET

✗ I am agree with you.
✓ I agree with you.
✗ She is live in Tokyo.
✓ She lives in Tokyo.

TRY IN A CORPUS `(am|is|are) (agree|live)`

L2 日本語→

2.3.2 Stative-Progressive Overextension

Progressive -ing spreads to stative verbs such as know, like and understand — a stage linked to the Aspect Hypothesis.

Key lit. Robison (1990) · Bardovi-Harlig (1998, 2000)

LEARNER vs TARGET

✗ I am knowing the answer.
✓ I know the answer.
✗ He is liking coffee.
✓ He likes coffee.

TRY IN A CORPUS `(am|is|are) (knowing|liking)`

CP (1): Topics and Relative Clauses

Structures at the left edge of the clause

L2 日本語 →

2.4.1 Topic-Comment Transfer

Topic-prominent L1 patterns (Japanese, Chinese) are overused. English allows them only in special contexts, so the result is often odd rather than impossible.

Key lit. Schachter & Rutherford (1979) · Fuller & Gundel (1987)

LEARNER vs TARGET

△ As for money, I don't have.

✓ I don't have any money.

△ This problem, I must think.

✓ I must think about this problem.

TRY IN A CORPUS `As for *,`

2.4.2 Resumptive Pronouns

A pronoun is kept in the gap inside a relative clause, where English requires the position to stay empty.

Key lit. Tarallo & Myhill (1983) · Hawkins (1989)

LEARNER vs TARGET

✗ The man who I saw **him** yesterday is my teacher.

✓ The man who I saw yesterday is my teacher.

TRY IN A CORPUS `who I saw (him|her)`

CP (2): Questions and Islands

Where wh-words can move — and where they cannot

2.4.3 Inversion in Indirect Questions

Subject-auxiliary inversion from direct questions is carried into embedded questions, which need declarative order.

Key lit. Felix (1982) · Lightbown & Spada (2013)

LEARNER vs TARGET

✗ I don't know where **is** he going.

✓ I don't know where he **is** going.

✗ Tell me what **do** you want.

✓ Tell me what you want.

TRY IN A CORPUS `know (where|what) (is|are|do)`

2.4.4 Island Constraint Violations

A wh-word is extracted from an "island", such as a relative clause. These are rare in corpora, so researchers usually test them with judgment tasks.

Key lit. Bley-Vroman, Felix & Ioup (1988) · Johnson & Newport (1989)

LEARNER vs TARGET

✗ What did you see the man who bought ___?

✓ What did the man you saw buy ___?

TRY IN A CORPUS → better tested by judgment task

Penn Treebank POS Tags

DP: Articles and Pronouns

What the noun phrase marks — and whether it appears at all

2.5.1 Article Choice

Learners fluctuate between marking definiteness and specificity, e.g. “the” for an entity only the speaker knows.

Key lit. Ionin, Ko & Wexler (2004) · Ionin et al. (2008)

LEARNER vs TARGET

✗ I bought **the** new laptop! (1st mention)
✓ I bought **a** new laptop!

TRY IN A CORPUS `count a / the per 1,000 words`

2.5.2 Null Subject / Object Transfer

Pro-drop from Japanese or Chinese: pronouns are left out where English requires them.

Key lit. White (1985) · Yuan (1997)

LEARNER vs TARGET

✗ Do you like it? — Yes, I like.
✓ Yes, I like **it**.

TRY IN A CORPUS `I like [.!]`

L2 日本語 →

2.5.3 Overuse of Overt Pronouns

The reverse: in null-subject languages, learners keep repeating pronouns the context already makes clear.

Key lit. Sorace & Serratrice (2009) · Sorace (2011)

LEARNER vs TARGET

△ Juan llegó. **Él** estaba cansado.
✓ Juan llegó. Estaba cansado.

TRY IN A CORPUS `count él / ella per clause`

Heads (1): Marking Tense on T

Doubled, regularized or missing inflection

2.6.1 Double Marking

One feature (tense, degree) is marked twice: on the auxiliary or modifier and on the verb or adjective.

Key lit. Lardiere (1998) · White (2003)

LEARNER vs TARGET

✗ He **did** went there.
✓ He went there.

TRY IN A CORPUS `did went|more cheaper`

L2 日本語 →

2.6.2 Overregularization

Regular rules (-ed, -s) are applied to irregular forms — a sign that the rule itself has been learned.

Key lit. Lardiere (1998) · Pinker (1999)

LEARNER vs TARGET

✗ goed · breaked · childs
✓ went · broke · children

TRY IN A CORPUS `goed|breaked|childs`

2.6.3 Missing Surface Inflection

-s and -ed are dropped variably, even though the underlying tense representation is in place (MSIH).

Key lit. Prévost & White (2000) · Lardiere (2007)

LEARNER vs TARGET

✗ Yesterday he **walk** home.
✓ Yesterday he walked home.

TRY IN A CORPUS `yesterday * walk`

Heads (2): Negation and V2

Where the finite verb ends up depends on L1 verb movement

2.6.4 Negation Placement

Where “not” goes depends on verb movement (V-to-T). French L1 learners raise the main verb past negation, as in French.

Key lit. White (1991) · Schwartz & Sprouse (1996)

LEARNER vs TARGET

✗ I **like** not spinach.

✓ I do not like spinach.

TRY IN A CORPUS `(like|know|want) not`

2.6.5 V2 Word Order in L2 German / Dutch

The finite verb must come second in main clauses. Learners fail to invert after an adverbial, or overapply V2 in subordinate clauses.

Key lit. Clahsen & Muysken (1986) · Meisel (1997)

LEARNER vs TARGET

✗ Gestern ich **ging** nach Hause.

✓ Gestern **ging** ich nach Hause.

TRY IN A CORPUS `Gestern (ich|er|sie)`

Interlanguage in L2 Japanese (1)

日本語学習者にも同じしくみが働く — same mechanisms, different target

cf.2.1.2 自動詞・他動詞の混同

Japanese has many verb pairs (開く/開ける). Learners pick the wrong member of the pair — a transitivity problem, like 2.1.2.

Key lit. 中石 (2004)

学習者 vs 母語話者

✗ ドアが 開け ました。
✓ ドアが 開き ました。

TRY IN A CORPUS が開けました

cf.2.3.2 「〜ている」の不使用

Mirror of English: “know” resists -ing, but 知る needs ている for a state. Learners use the plain form.

Key lit. Shirai & Kurono (1998)

学習者 vs 母語話者

✗ 答えを 知り ます。 (= I know)
✓ 答えを 知っています。

TRY IN A CORPUS 知ります

cf.2.4.1 「は」と「が」

Topic は is overextended to positions that need subject が, e.g. a wh-subject.

Key lit. 野田・迫田・渋谷・小林 (2001)

学習者 vs 母語話者

✗ 誰は来ましたか。
✓ 誰が来ましたか。

TRY IN A CORPUS 誰は | 何は

Penn Treebank POS Tags

Interlanguage in L2 Japanese (2)

Overgeneralized rules and pronoun choices

cf.DP 「の」の過剰使用

The N-の-N rule is stretched to adjectives and relative clauses. Reported across many L1 backgrounds.

Key lit. 奥野 (2002)

学習者 vs 母語話者

✗ 大きいの犬 / 先生が書いたの論文
✓ 大きい犬 / 先生が書いた論文

TRY IN A CORPUS いの + 名詞

cf.2.5.3 「私は」「彼は」の多用

English-speaking learners repeat pronouns that Japanese would drop — 2.5.3 in a language you know well.

Key lit. cf. Sorace (2011)

学習者 vs 母語話者

△ 私は学生です。私は毎朝走ります。
✓ 私は学生です。毎朝走ります。

TRY IN A CORPUS 私は per 100 sentences

cf.2.6.2 活用の過剰規則化

The regular rule (書く→書いた) is applied to irregular 行く, just like “goed”.

Key lit. illustrative example

学習者 vs 母語話者

✗ 昨日、京都に行いた。
✓ 昨日、京都に行った。

TRY IN A CORPUS 行いた|行きた

Penn Treebank POS Tags

Learner Corpora You Can Explore

Large collections of real learner writing and speech, searchable by anyone

LEARNER ENGLISH

ICNALE — Essays and speech by learners across Asia, incl. Japan, plus native-speaker controls

NICT JLE — Spoken English of Japanese learners, from oral proficiency interviews

ICLE — Argumentative essays by advanced EFL university students with many L1s

LEARNER JAPANESE

I-JAS — NINJAL corpus of learners of Japanese from 12 L1 backgrounds, plus native speakers

KY Corpus — Oral proficiency interviews with learners of Japanese (Chinese, English, Korean L1)

中納言 — NINJAL's web search interface — I-JAS can be searched here

Tools `AntConc` is a free concordancer: load learner texts and search for any word, phrase or pattern. Compare the learner data with native-speaker data from the same corpus.

How to Search: Three Moves

Find the form, compare with native speakers, then explain

1 Find

Search for the form, e.g. was happened. Read every hit in context — some will be false alarms.

2 Compare

Count hits per 10,000 words in learner and native data. Raw counts mislead when corpora differ in size.

3 Explain

L1 transfer? A rule stretched too far? A developmental stage? Check learners with different L1s.

WHAT A CONCORDANCE (KWIC) LOOKS LIKE · format example

I don’t know what	**was happened**	to him after the
Everyone asked me what	**is happened**	in the classroom .
The accident	**was happened**	last year near my
Nobody knew why it	**happened**	. It was a big

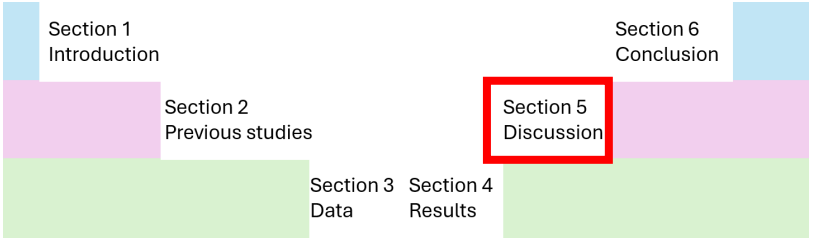
Penn Treebank POS Tags

Errors Are Data

Every “mistake” is a window into a learner’s grammar. Pick one, search a corpus, and bring back the evidence.

`(is|was) happened` `(am|is) agree` `explained me` `know where is`

`いの + 名詞` `goed|行いた`



IV Critical re-evaluation of previous accounts with the corpus data

1 Against the transfer account

Because of the overwhelming evidence that speakers of the languages without a grammatically equivalent structure produce 'passive' unaccusatives in their IL English, I have argued that the L1 transfer analysis is at best a weak explanation for the 'passive' unaccusative phenomenon. This conclusion is again supported by the corpus data since 'passive' unaccusatives were found in the data from L1 speakers of Japanese and Korean.

The critical question, therefore, is the plausibility of the weak version of the transfer account in (14). Are speakers of a language with a compound tense/aspect structure that resembles the *be* + *en* in IL English more susceptible to 'passive' unaccusative errors than are the speakers of a language without it? One way to answer this question is to see how prevalent 'passive' errors are among the non-target tokens in the data from each language group. To this end, we need to look at the data that fall outside the apparently target-like NP–V structure. In addition, since the L1 transfer account is concerned only with the morphosyntactic use of unaccusative verbs, we need to exclude from consideration the lexical innovation of nonce causative verbs of (33i) and the existential pseudo-relatives in (33j). This is because the former is clearly a lexical error, and the latter most likely has to do with a typological characteristic of the learner's L1 such as topic prominence, which may lead to an avoidance of indefinite subjects (Jordens, 1995; Yip, 1995: Chapter 7; see also Oshita, 1997: Appendix B). The remaining data are shown in Table 2, separated between the 'passive' unaccusative structure and the other syntactic errors.

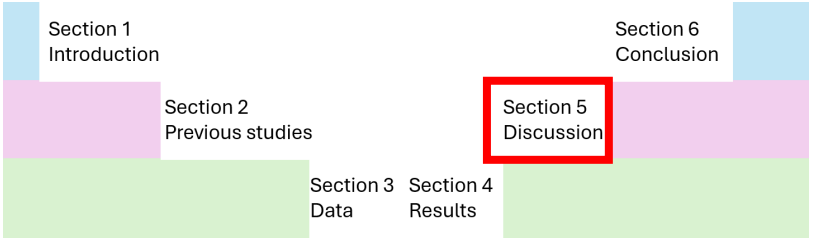
Section 4 The corpus analysis

Implications for the existing analysis

(Approach 1) L1 Transfer

1) Prediction:
2) Data (Results):
3) Evaluation:

Three important perspectives



The distribution of the data in Table 2 by the 'passive' unaccusative structure and the other syntactic errors are plotted in Figure 1, which reveals an interesting picture. While the overall numbers of the two kinds of errors are approximately the same, 'passive' unaccusatives are more common than the other syntactic errors in the Korean and Japanese data, but exactly the opposite is the case in the data from the Italian and Spanish groups. Moreover, despite the expectation based on the weak transfer account, 'passive' errors are not as prevalent among the non NP–V tokens in the Italian data as they are in the Korean and Japanese data. In fact, while 80% (8/10) and 70.8% (17/24) of non NP–V tokens are of the 'passive' unaccusative type for the L1 Korean and L1 Japanese data, only 36.4% (8/22) of them are attributable to the *be* + *en* structure in the L1 Italian data. In other words, the corpus data show that while 'passive' unaccusative errors are relatively few in the Italian data, they constitute the majority of the syntactic errors committed by the Korean and Japanese subjects. This is an unexpected result if L1 transfer is a major factor. The finding, therefore, suggests that even the weak interpretation of the transfer account is difficult to maintain. (Incidentally, notice that despite the lack of a comparable tense/aspect system characterized by the *be* + *en*, the Spanish data mirror the Italian pattern, not the Korean/Japanese one; this is an observation relevant to the discussion in footnote 16.) Thus, the knowledge of a compound tense/aspect structure in one's L1 appears to have minimal effect on the 'passive' unaccusative errors in IL English.[14]

Section 4 The corpus analysis

Implications for the existing analysis

(Approach 1) L1 Transfer

1) **Prediction:**

   a. German/Italian more errors

   b. Japanese/Korean fewer errors

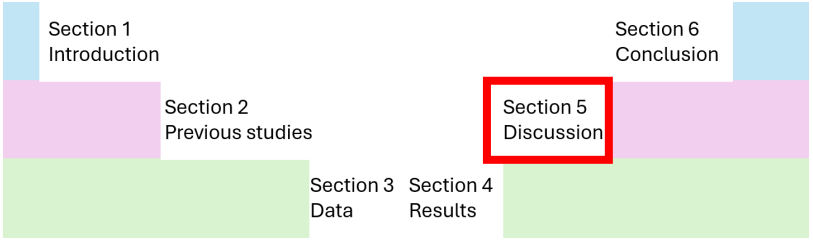
2) **Data (Results):**

   a. German/Italian fewer errors

   b. Japanese/Korean more errors

3) **Evaluation:**

   Difficult to maintain.



2 Against the adjectival passive account

The plausibility of the adjectival passive account crucially depends on the semantic interpretation of the past participles in the 'passive' unaccusative structure. Since adjectival passives describe a state that results from an event denoted by the base verb, actual 'passive' errors should be interpretable as learners' attempts to describe states rather than dynamic events.

Looking at the data obtained from the LLC, however, it is clear that most, if not all, of the 38 tokens of 'passive' unaccusatives lack a stative meaning. Although this lack of stative meaning is apparent within the immediate context of each token sentence, it becomes especially evident when additional linguistic cues such as time, frequency and manner adverbials appear with a nontarget *be* + *en*:

36) a. * . . . they were happened *a few days ago* . . . (L1 Italian)
b. * . . . terrorism is happened *very often* . . . (L1 Korean)
c. * . . . *suddenly* pale face was appeared out of the window . . . (L1 Korean)
d. * *Two or three days ago*, the important trouble was happened. (L1 Japanese)

Furthermore, one of the obtained examples is based on *exist*, an inherently stative verb:

37) * . . . this kind of problem will be exist forever . . .

As discussed in the review section, this type of error does not lend itself to the adjectival passive account since morphosyntactic marking of the inherently stative verb is simply redundant.

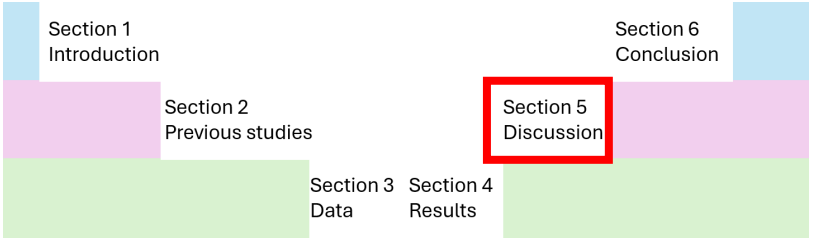
In sum, therefore, the adjectival passive account of the 'passive' unaccusative structure, which appeared rather weak in light of the existing data, does not receive support from the corpus study either.

Section 4 The corpus analysis

Implications for the existing analysis
(Approach 1) L1 Transfer
(Approach 2) Overgeneralized adj.

1) Prediction:
2) Data (Results):
3) Evaluation:

Three important perspectives



IV Critical re-evaluation of previous accounts with the corpus data

1 Against the transfer account

Because of the overwhelming evidence that speakers of the languages without a grammatically equivalent structure produce 'passive' unaccusatives in their IL English, I have argued that the L1 transfer analysis is at best a weak explanation for the 'passive' unaccusative phenomenon. This conclusion is again supported by the corpus data since 'passive' unaccusatives were found in the data from L1 speakers of Japanese and Korean.

The critical question, therefore, is the plausibility of the weak version of the transfer account in (14). Are speakers of a language with a compound tense/aspect structure that resembles the *be* + *en* in IL English more susceptible to 'passive' unaccusative errors than are the speakers of a language without it? One way to answer this question is to see how prevalent 'passive' errors are among the non-target tokens in the data from each language group. To this end, we need to look at the data that fall outside the apparently target-like NP–V structure. In addition, since the L1 transfer account is concerned only with the morphosyntactic use of unaccusative verbs, we need to exclude from consideration the lexical innovation of nonce causative verbs of (33i) and the existential pseudo-relatives in (33j). This is because the former is clearly a lexical error, and the latter most likely has to do with a typological characteristic of the learner's L1 such as topic prominence, which may lead to an avoidance of indefinite subjects (Jordens, 1995; Yip, 1995: Chapter 7; see also Oshita, 1997: Appendix B). The remaining data are shown in Table 2, separated between the 'passive' unaccusative structure and the other syntactic errors.

Section 4 The corpus analysis

Implications for the existing analysis

(Approach 1) L1 Transfer

1) **Prediction:**

a. German/Italian more errors

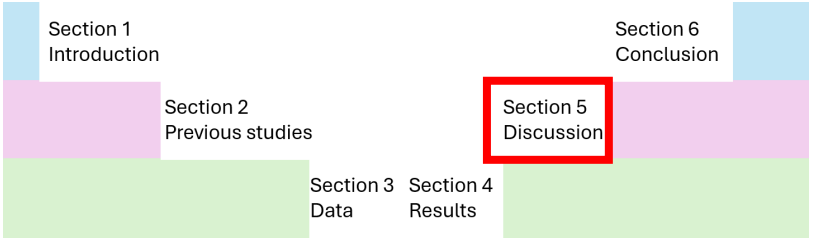
b. Japanese/Korean fewer errors

2) **Data (Results):**

Table 2 The 'passive' unaccusative structure versus the other syntactic errors

Nontarget structures	Italian	Spanish	Korean	Japanese	Total
'Passive' unaccusatives (ii)	8	5	8	17	38
Other syntactic errors (iii)–(viii)	14	14	2	7	37
Total	22	19	10	24	75

3) **Evaluation:**



2 Against the adjectival passive account

The plausibility of the adjectival passive account crucially depends on the semantic interpretation of the past participles in the 'passive' unaccusative structure. Since adjectival passives describe a state that results from an event denoted by the base verb, actual 'passive' errors should be interpretable as learners' attempts to describe states rather than dynamic events.

Looking at the data obtained from the LLC, however, it is clear that most, if not all, of the 38 tokens of 'passive' unaccusatives lack a stative meaning. Although this lack of stative meaning is apparent within the immediate context of each token sentence, it becomes especially evident when additional linguistic cues such as time, frequency and manner adverbials appear with a nontarget *be* + *en*:

36) a. * . . . they were happened *a few days ago* . . . (L1 Italian)
b. * . . . terrorism is happened *very often* . . . (L1 Korean)
c. * . . . *suddenly* pale face was appeared out of the window . . . (L1 Korean)
d. * *Two or three days ago*, the important trouble was happened. (L1 Japanese)

Furthermore, one of the obtained examples is based on *exist*, an inherently stative verb:

37) * . . . this kind of problem will be exist forever . . .

As discussed in the review section, this type of error does not lend itself to the adjectival passive account since morphosyntactic marking of the inherently stative verb is simply redundant.

In sum, therefore, the adjectival passive account of the 'passive' unaccusative structure, which appeared rather weak in light of the existing data, does not receive support from the corpus study either.

Section 4 The corpus analysis

Implications for the existing analysis
(Approach 1) L1 Transfer
(Approach 2) Overgeneralized adj.

1) **Prediction:**

a. Dynamic events: fewer errors
b. States: more errors

2) **Data (Results):**

a. Dynamic events: more errors
b. States: fewer errors

3) **Evaluation:**

Difficult to maintain.